

DIGNIFIED DELETION

*What if not everything
should be preserved?*

Our mission is not to preserve everything forever,
but to make thoughtful decisions about what should
remain—and what should be allowed to return
to the digital forest floor.



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ABSTRACT

This presentation challenges the assumption that our mission is to save as much as possible, for as long as possible. Drawing on ecological concepts of decay, regeneration, and the forest floor, it proposes a philosophy of "graceful" degradation and "dignified deletion"—frameworks for intentionally letting some digital objects die. It explores five interconnected provocations and introduces a framework for principled deaccessioning: documentation, redistribution, retention policies, sunset metadata, and transparent endings.

KEYWORDS

digital preservation ethics, deaccessioning, sustainability, planned obsolescence, collection management, storage, environmental impact, curatorial practice

FIVE PROVOCATIONS



1. DECAY IS INFRASTRUCTURE

In nature, death is not failure—it is infrastructure. Decay builds soil, enables new life, and keeps systems healthy. What would a "composting" model of digital preservation look like?



2. PRESERVATION HAS A CLIMATE COST

Data centers use 1–2% of global electricity today, projected to reach 8% by 2030. Can infinite preservation be compatible with climate responsibility?



3. SOME OBJECTS ARE MEANT TO DISAPPEAR

Ephemeral messages, stories, and works are designed to be temporary. When we preserve them, we may change what they were meant to be.



4. WE CREATE PRESERVATION DEBT

Every object we ingest creates obligations for future colleagues: migrations, metadata, storage, and care. Debt compounds.



5. SOMETIMES DELETION IS CARE

Retention can cause harm. Respecting privacy, consent, and community wishes means that deletion may be the most ethical choice.

A FRAMEWORK FOR DIGNIFIED DELETION



A DOCUMENTATION BEFORE DELETION
Create metadata describing what existed, why it was collected, and why it is being released. Preserve intellectual access, even when bits are no longer retained.

B REDISTRIBUTION OPPORTUNITIES
Actively seek other institutions that might provide better stewardship. "Not here" need not mean "nowhere".

C TRANSPARENT RETENTION POLICIES
Establish and communicate retention periods for different collection types. Set clear expectations and accountability.

D SUNSET METADATA
Embed intentional expiration dates from acquisition. Make planned obsolescence visible and actionable.

E RITUAL AND RECOGNITION
Acknowledge impact, honor contributors and users, and document the life and legacy of collections.



*“The forest floor teaches us
that death makes room
for new life.”*

KEY QUESTION

Is our mission to preserve everything forever—
or to make thoughtful decisions about
what should remain?

THE NUMBERS WE MUST CONSIDER



1–2%
of global electricity
is used by data centers
today.



8%
projected data center
electricity use by
2030.



30K–50K
people's water usage
can equal that of a single
data center.



Dignified deletion is not abandonment;
it is curation. It asks preservation professionals
to exercise judgment about endings with the
same care we reserve for beginnings.

